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Unit 3

The Age of Empires: Guptas and Vardhanas



EPLTXU

Learning Objectives

- To know the establishment of Gupta dynasty and the empire-building efforts of Gupta rulers
- To understand the polity, economy and society under Guptas
- To get familiar with the contributions of the Guptas to art, architecture, literature, education, science and technology
- To explore the signification of the reign of HarshaVardhana

Introduction

By the end of the 3rd century AD (CE), the powerful empires established by the Kushanas in the north and Satavahanas in the south had lost their greatness and strength. After the decline of Kushanas and Satavahanas, Chandragupta carved out a kingdom and establish his dynastic rule, which lasted for about two hundred years.

After the downfall of the Guptas and thereafter and interregnum of nearly 50 years, Harsha of Vardhana dynasty ruled North India from 606 to 647 A.D (CE).

Sources

Archaeological Sources

- Gold, silver and copper coins issued by Gupta rulers.
- Allahabad Pillar Inscription of Samudragupta.
- The Mehrauli Iron Pillar Inscription.
- Udayagiri Cave Inscription, Mathura Stone Inscription and Sanchi Stone Inscription of Chandragupta II.
- Bhitari Pillar Inscription of Skandagupta.
- The Gadhwa Stone Inscription.

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